

AKHLĀQ

(ETIQUETTE)



CHAPTER 1

Mind, Body and Soul

- 1.1 Practically Achieving Our Purpose
- 1.2 Balance and Moderation
- 1.3 Self-Esteem and Self-Confidence

1.1 Practically Achieving Our Purpose

OBJECTIVES

WE WILL:

- Analyze the perspectives of celebrities and what their purpose in life is.
- Identify the real purpose of life.
- Identify the meaning of true happiness.
- Compare and contrast the perspectives of celebrities to those of the true role models.

SUPPLEMENTAL VIDEO:



<https://bit.ly/3psmBLc>
(Start at 1:21; end at 3:47)

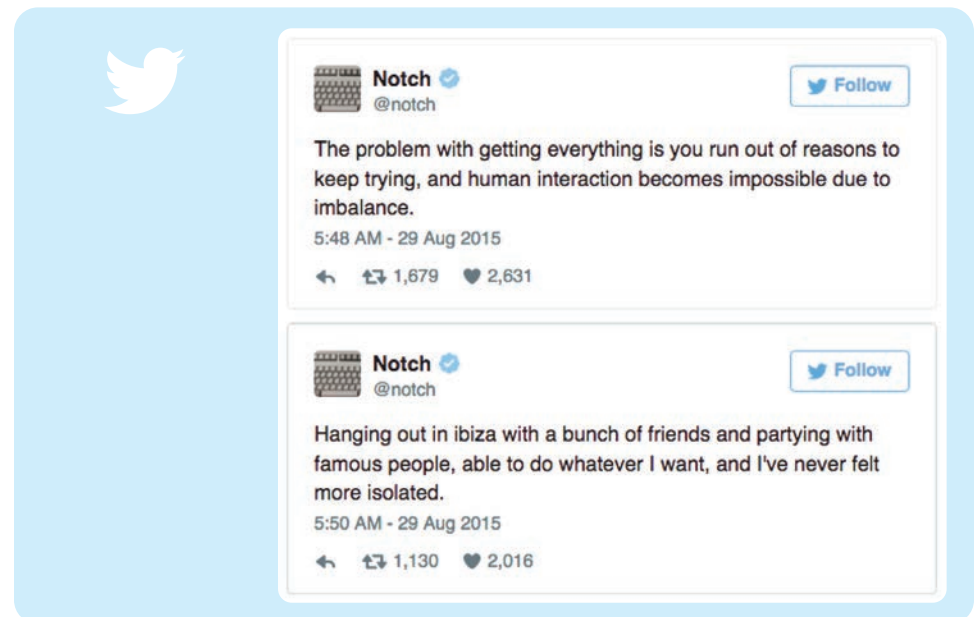
Activity 1.1a: Pre-Reading Reflection

Answer the following questions in pairs, or as a class:

1. What do celebrities have that others do not have?
2. Is there a difference between how believers see a celebrity versus non-believers? If so, what is the main difference?
3. Do you think celebrities are typically satisfied with their lives?
4. Does what they have make them feel like they have achieved their full potential?

Typically, when most celebrities talk about themselves, they admit that their celebrity success has not given them much satisfaction in their lives, even though they have a lot of wealth and fame.

For example, in 2014, the founder of Minecraft purchased a 70 million dollar mansion in a neighborhood known as Billionaire's Row in California. It had a special wall just for candy, 14 bedrooms, 15 bathrooms, and a \$5,600 toilet. The media reported that sometimes he spends \$180,000 in one night on parties. Despite having access to so much wealth, he expressed his emotions on Twitter as follows:



When we look at the lives of celebrities, they tend to have almost everything imaginable in this world in a material sense. The founder of Minecraft was able to build his home with everything he could have desired. However, once he accomplished having a house like this, he was still not happy. What else could he possibly need?



STOP AND REFLECT: What is true happiness—if despite having vast amounts of wealth and fame—people still cannot attain it?

In reality, everything in this world is only temporary. This celebrity was trying to fulfill his eternal being with temporary happiness. He did not realize that he can only make his eternal being happy by pursuing what is the Absolute Infinite—which is only Allah ﷻ. This man made his material possessions—in this case his house and wealth—his goal in life, thinking that it would bring him happiness.

Happiness is an emotional state that is often commonly misunderstood by some people as being related to material possessions. However, these temporary, worldly things do not give a person true happiness. True happiness is found in being aligned with one's purpose in life. Obtaining real happiness comes with working hard while facing the difficulties of living life. In the Noble Qur'an, the words *sa'ādah* and *falāḥ* are used for true happiness, and they can be translated as: success, prosperity, and happiness.



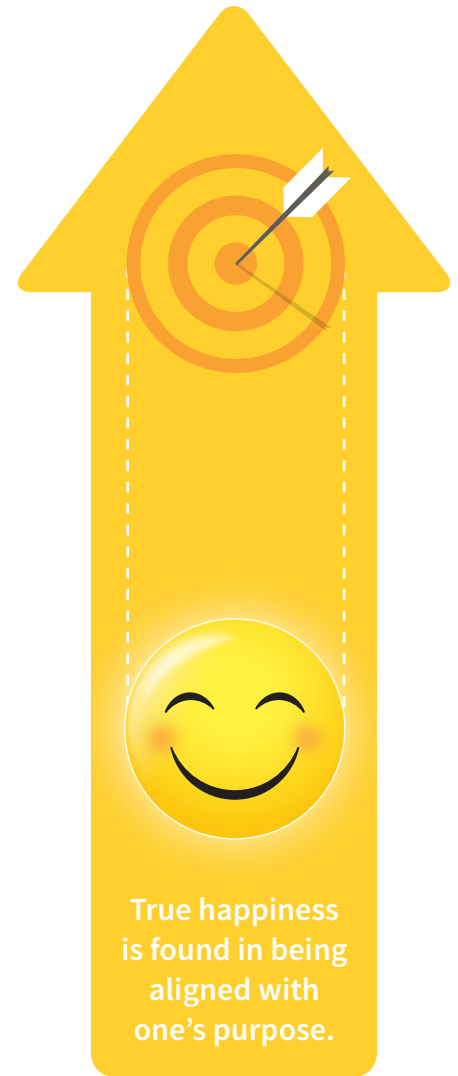
STOP AND REFLECT: In the calls to the daily prayers—adhān and iqāmah—we are encouraged to rush toward *falāḥ* (success, prosperity, and happiness) where it says: “Ḥayyā ‘alal falāḥ.” What do you think the connection between prayer (*ṣalāh*) and prosperity (*falāḥ*) is?

Islam has taught us how to attain true happiness in our own lives. When Prophet Muḥammad ﷺ was asked about true success or happiness (*sa'ādah*), he replied: “A long life in obedience to Allah.” Allah ﷻ is the All-Knowing and the All-Perfect Creator, and the path that He has chosen for us and guided us to—Islam—is the only thing that will lead us to true happiness. Allah ﷻ says in the Noble Qur'an in Sūrah Ṭāḥā:

Then whoever follows My guidance will neither go astray, nor will they be miserable. But whoever forgets (or turns away from) My remembrance will have a wretched (or straitened) life...¹

Even if the circumstances in our lives are very difficult, or we have just a few material possessions, we can still feel happiness in knowing that we are striving toward a higher purpose and potential, and that Allah ﷻ is taking care of us. When we look at people whose goals and aims for success are only limited to this world, although they may obtain some temporary happiness, they will never have real happiness in those goals. Whereas in true happiness, one can live a life full of constant difficulties, but still be content and happy with what they have.

Consider, for example, the lives of our Ahlul Bayt ﷺ; even though they suffered so much in their lives and faced many difficulties, they were still happy knowing that they were on the path of Allah ﷻ.



¹ Noble Qur'an, Sūrah Ṭāḥā (20), Verses 123-124.

Activity 1.1b: Think, Pair, Share

With a partner, answer the following questions, then share your answers with the class:

1. How do people become celebrities? What is this usually based on?

2. Would it be fair if only celebrities could go to Heaven? Why or why not?

WHO ARE THE REAL CELEBRITIES?

People often become celebrities based on their looks, voices, or talents. If being a celebrity was **the** ticket to success, we would say that is not fair or just. Or if being a celebrity was the only way to get to Heaven, we would say this is injustice. If being rich and famous were where our successes came from, you could never be satisfied with your life unless you were a celebrity. We would have to ask, what about the people who do not have what it takes to become celebrities?

Islam teaches us that everyone can become a “celebrity” in the true sense of the word: meaning that when they achieve their God-given potential, and are celebrated by Allah ﷻ, the Ahlul Bayt ﷺ, and the angels. Allah ﷻ says in the Qur’ān:

“It is He who blesses you, and so do His angels, that He may bring you out from the darkneses into the light; and He is to the faithful, All-Merciful.”²

The Prophet ﷺ said: “Verily Allah, the High, boasts about the worshiping of the young people to His angels, saying: ‘Look at My servant! They have abandoned their desires for My sake.’”³

People who equate happiness to fame and fortune also find it difficult to go through hardships like sickness, aging, or loss of popularity. But no one is able to escape whatever Allah ﷻ has decreed for them, even if they have money and fame. People who are on the right path in terms of attaining their full potential come to terms with the realities of this world, and are able to bear the difficulties that it entails. They live much happier lives than some famous celebrities who base their lives on fake, unrealistic ideals.

Oftentimes, we are bombarded with information about the lives of Hollywood celebrities, and an image of who they are. We should look at the lives of the shuhadā’—those who lived and died in the way of Allah ﷻ—in order to understand a different way of living. If a person wants to become a martyr (shahīd), they need to be very close to Allah ﷻ, and follow His guidelines about how to live one’s life in His servitude and obedience.



STOP AND REFLECT: What kind of a person is able to become a martyr (*shahīd*)? Can you think of any examples?

² Noble Qur’ān, Sūrah al-Aḥzāb (33), Verse 43.

³ Muttaqī Hindī, *Kanz al-‘Ummāl*, Ḥadīth #43057.

SHAHĪD BEHESHTĪ

One of the great martyrs (shuhadā') in recent times is Shahīd Beheshtī. He was a great leader, and a very learned scholar who was killed in Iran in 1979.

He tried to seek knowledge from a very young age. When he was fourteen years old, he started studying Theology in the Ṣadr Theology School of Iṣfahān in Iran. As a scholar, he would prepare thoroughly in order to be able to share his knowledge with other people. He took advantage of every moment he could find to study and learn in order to be thorough in his research. Once, he was invited to an academic conference where he was asked to prove that the Qur'ān, unlike the Bible and the Torah, is the original revelation of Allah ﷻ, and has never been altered by human beings. As part of his thorough preparation for this conference, he read 82 books in English, not to mention other books and articles in various languages.

Another time, Shahīd Beheshtī started a weekly discussion session with four university professors on the topic of Economics. After a few months, the professors admitted that their knowledge about Economics was shallow. Instead of discussing Economics together like they were all peers, they wanted to become Shahīd Beheshtī's students, and turn the discussion session into a class. Due to the attention that a true ḥawzah student gives to subjects, Shahīd Beheshtī knew it in a lot of depth, and the others wanted to learn it in detail right from the roots from him.

In an interview, Shahīd Beheshtī's wife once said: *"Despite my husband being very busy, it was not possible for him to arrive at a meeting later than the agreed upon time. He was very organized and punctual. He used to say: 'If we cannot be organized about our day-to-day affairs, then how can we possibly help the government to advance?'"* He was also very kind to his family. His wife said that she does not recall even a single incident where he became angry for no valid reason.

Shahīd Beheshtī used to tell his students: "Do not say that 'If only I had such-and-such a thing, I would do this...' Instead with whatever you have, ask yourself 'What is the best thing I can do?'"

Shahīd Beheshtī lived his life in a way that all of his actions were for the sake of Allah ﷻ. Imām Ja'far aṣ-Ṣādiq ؑ said: "Above every act of goodness is another act of goodness, until one were to be killed in the way of Allah. When one is killed in the way of Allah, the Magnificent and Exalted, there is no greater act than that."⁴



STOP AND REFLECT: What is meant by the above narration (*ḥadīth*) of the 6th Imām ؑ?

One of the meanings could be that people who live sincere, pure lives of truth, and are killed or die in this way have attained the highest act of goodness.



Sayyid Muhammad Husayni Beheshti

4 Ḥurr 'Āmilī, Muḥammad ibn Ḥasan, *Wasā'il ash-Shī'ah*, Vol. 11, P. 10.



REFLECTING ON OUR OWN LIVES

Through the resources that we have been given by Allah ﷻ, we have access to all sorts of role models. When we look at the celebrities who are adored by people today, we see that many of them lack true contentment; but on the other hand, we can find Islamic role models throughout the ages who inspire us to be better people. The lives of martyrs like Shahīd Beheshtī—who strove for righteous ideals and the truth, and used whatever time and blessings he was given by Allah ﷻ to spread His cause—give us a different perspective on what life is all about, and who truly shines in the view of Allah ﷻ.

When it comes to our own lives, we have to accept the reality of life in this world. We will be tested in this life because it is the way that Allah ﷻ has determined for us to grow and get closer to Him. Things will not always work out the way we expect them to, but this is a test from Allah ﷻ, and the ability to realize this is a great blessing from Allah ﷻ. When we do things, we have to realize and perform our own responsibilities (*taklīf*), and have trust (*tawakkul*) in Allah ﷻ.

When we fulfill our responsibilities and have full trust in the plan of the Almighty, we will become closer to Him. We should try to do this in every aspect of our lives. When we are in school for example, we may not always get the grades that we are looking for, even if we try our best. We might get assigned to be with group partners who do not do their work, or have a hard time finding the right set of friends. All of these are tests from Allah ﷻ, even if we may not realize it. Getting past these trials, and realizing that our ultimate goal and purpose in life is closeness to Allah ﷻ, is how we will be able to grow.

TAKLĪF: responsibility

TAWAKKUL: trust

Activity 1.1c: Achieving our Goals

For this activity, we have listed some goals or purposes that people might be striving to achieve. Think of as many examples as you can of actions which a person might take to reach that goal. Start with small steps, then lead to bigger things. End with the most drastic actions that one needs to take.

GOAL	ACTIONS
Become the best at a video game	Small: Practice the video game every day. Medium: Drastic: Quit school/work to become the best at that video game.
Become the most famous person on Youtube	Small: Medium: Vlog everyday and pay \$\$ to promote your blogs. Drastic:
Be seen as the most beautiful/ attractive and stay youthful	Small: Start wearing sunscreen and get good moisturizing cream. Medium: Drastic:
Become a billionaire	Small: Medium: Drastic: Start a company that exploits people to get rich quick.

In the activity above, there is a clear relationship between the goals people have, and the actions that they are taking to achieve them. For example, if you are trying to be the best in a certain video game, then it is obvious from your actions how much you are prioritizing that goal. If you practice it once

in a while, there may be other parts of your life that you are prioritizing. If you are quitting school to become the best at video games, then you are prioritizing video games in your life. When we reflect on our own actions, we need to see what we are prioritizing in life.